Forum: **Security Council (SC)**

Issue: Addressing Escalating Regional Instability in the Sahel.

Student Officer: Leo Du, Julian Chiu

Position: President Chair, Deputy Chair

Introduction

The Sahel region is a semi-arid belt that lies astride the Maghreb States and stretches from the Atlantic Ocean to the Red Sea, spanning around 10 million square kilometers. The region is rich in natural resources such as minerals, which attracts foreign powers. The region, especially in the Western Sahel, experiences frequent shortage of food and water. Not only is this due to the harsh climate conditions, but also government corruption as well as recurring political instability.

The Sahel region has been evolving into a large-scale humanitarian and security crisis, evident in the rise of extremist violence, political instability, and economic failures. A string of military coups across the Sahel in countries such as Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger, have undermined existing democratic structures while also limiting state response to growing security threats. Armed extremist groups, such as Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimin (JNIM) and Islamic State Sahel Province (IS-SP), have exploited this vulnerability to extend their attacks across borders. They carry out deadly attacks against civilians and security forces, resulting in numerous casualties and widespread internal displacement.

The crisis has grown over time within the Sahel region and now threatens to spill into neighboring states outside of the Sahel to the coasts of West. The Lake Chad Basin has also similarly seen activities of terrorist groups such as Boko Haram, creating insecurity along borderlands, exacerbating internal displacement, and straining already limited national resources. In addition, the regional climate has been heavily impacted by climate change, leading to challenges of food scarcity, and the already weak infrastructure have amplified the existing vulnerabilities within affected populations across nations, contributing to the overall crisis.

As of present, the Security Council must address the deteriorating situation in the Sahel, including strengthening regional security cooperation, supporting humanitarian assistance, and promoting political stability, while ensuring that all measures remain consistent with the principles of the Charter of the United Nations and international law.

Definition of Key Terms

Sahel Region

A semi-arid belt stretching across Africa from Senegal to Sudan. The region is characterized by its significant governance challenges, climate vulnerability and ongoing conflict.

Jihadist Insurgency

A rebellion carried out by extremist Islamic groups, seeking to establish governance based on their interpretation of the Islamic law.

Non-State Armed Groups

Independent militant organizations such as JNIM, IS-SP and Boko Haram that operate independently, not formally under any government control.

Al-Qaeda-affiliated Groups

Extremist organizations that are ideologically aligned with or directly linked to al-Qaeda, such as JNIM. They usually focus on local integration and long-term insurgency.

Coup d'ètat

The sudden overthrow of a government, usually by military forces.

Foreign Military Intervention

The military involvement of external countries or forces in a conflict in forms of training, logistical support or troops. In the Sahel region, the two most involved are France and Russia.

Background

Geography and Environmental Context

The Sahel region is a semi-arid transitional belt which forms the boundary between the Sahara Desert to the north and the fertile savannahs of the south. It covers parts of Mauritania, Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, Chad, and Sudan. Historically, the region supported trans-Saharan trade networks and diverse communities, whose daily lives depend closely on seasonal rainfall patterns.

Figure 1: Geographical map of the Sahel region (Britannica)

However, the Sahel has become increasingly vulnerable environmentally. Cyclical droughts, desertification, and erratic rainfall have contributed to food insecurity and resource competition. Recently, climate change has intensified these hazards, reducing farmable land and water availability while increasing the frequency of extreme weather events.

Colonial Legacy and State Formation (Late 19th century to 1960s)

During the late 19th century, European colonial powers, particularly France, incorporated much of the Sahel into colonial administrations of French West Africa. Colonial borders were drawn without considering ethnic, cultural, or economic differences, dividing communities and disrupting traditional governance systems. Colonial administrations prioritized resource extraction, leaving behind weak frameworks after Sahel states gained independence.

After decolonization in the 1960s, newly independent states had to deal with the fragile political systems and the limited infrastructure, and economies heavily dependent on agriculture and external aid. Governance challenges, including corruption and limited state presence in rural areas, contributed to persistent instability and underdevelopment.

Post-Colonial Instability and Structural Fragility (1970s–2000s)

In the late 20th century, Sahelian states were in a state of constant political instability, experiencing multiple coups that led to authoritarian rulers being placed in power. Economic challenges were made worse from repeated droughts which caused widespread famine and displacement, making nations reach their boiling points and have people resort to violence in order to push for change.

In countries like Mali and Niger, tensions between central governments and ethnic minorities in the northern regions, such as Tuareg communities, have led to violent rebel activities. These conflicts were often caused by perceived political exclusion as well as resource scarcity. While peace agreements were reached temporarily, many disputes remain unsolved and have been out on hiatus.

Rise of Extremism and Regional Conflict (2011–Present)

The Sahel crisis has a close link to the aftermath of the Libyan Civil War, as state authority in Libya collapsed, large quantities of weapons were dispensed across the region. Armed fighters, including Tuareg rebellions, used these weapons to start the Mali War in 2012, during which northern territories were taken over by militants looking to form the autonomous entity of Azawad.

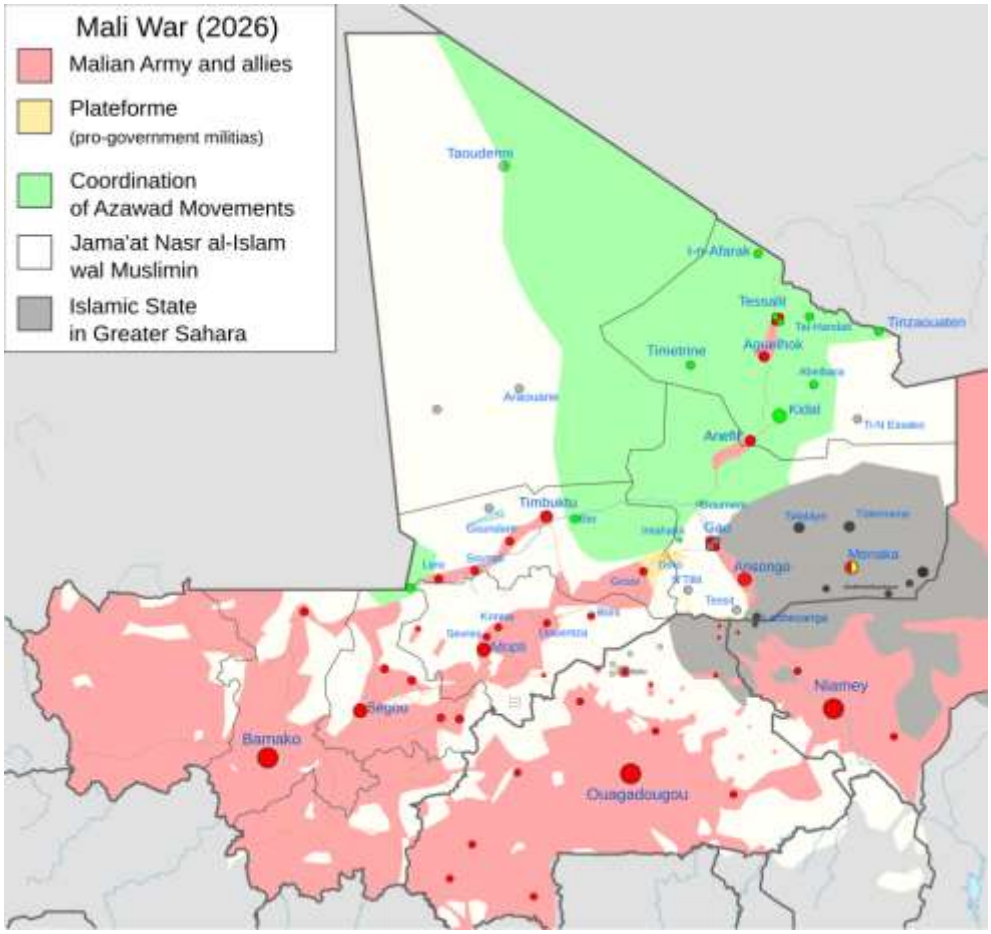

Figure 2: Conflict map of the Mali War ("File:MaliWar.svg - Wikimedia Commons")

Using the conflict, jihadist groups also joined in, taking up chunks of territories to use as a base for launching attacks across the region. The Mali War is still ongoing as of today, with the nation witnessing continued fighting for 14 years.

Jihadist organizations, including Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimin and Islamic State Sahel Province, have conducted cross border operations which exploit the weak governance and limited state presence. These groups utilize asymmetric tactics, targeting civilians, security forces, and infrastructure, while also establishing their own authoritarian rule in captured territories. Their activities have peaked in recent times, as they continue to take advantage of the heavy instability in the Sahel.

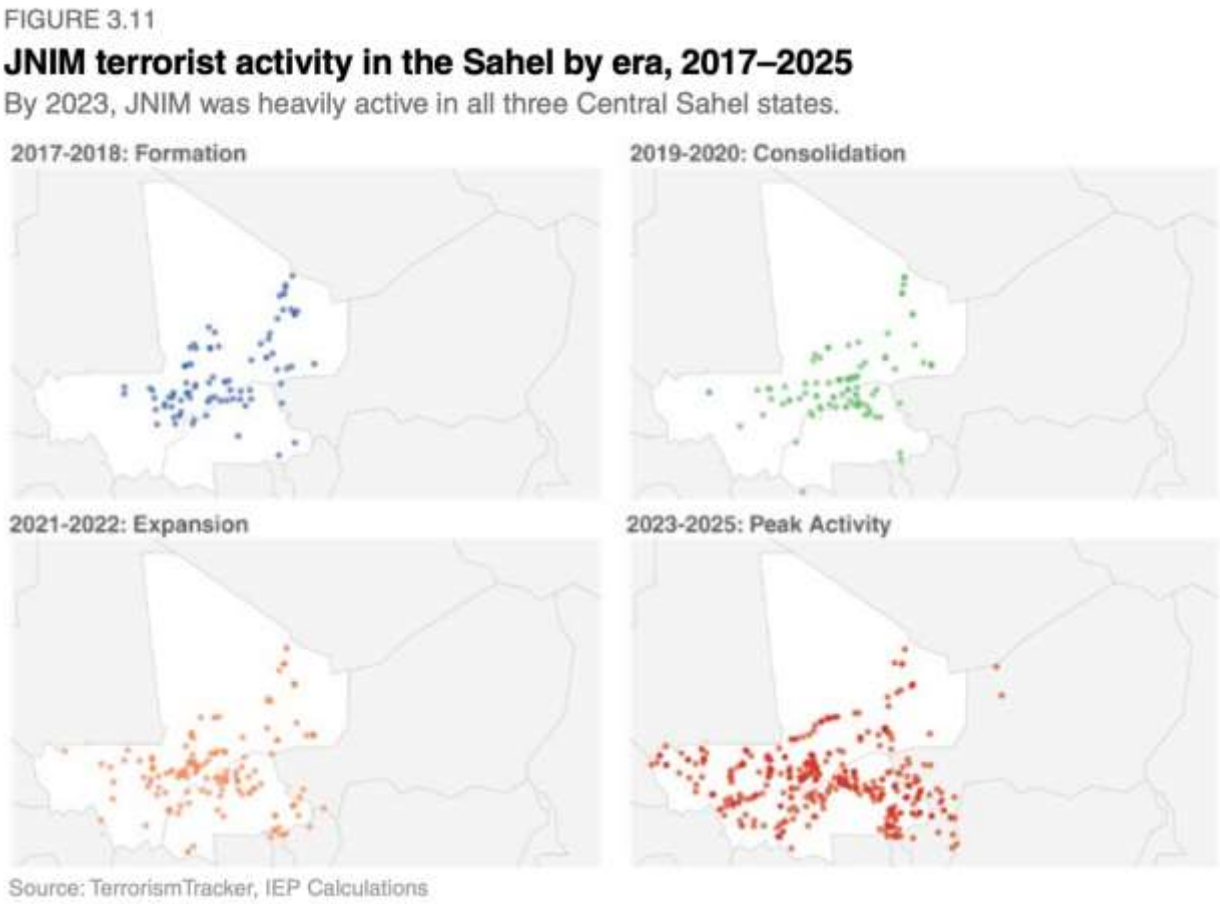

Figure 4: JNIM activity within the Sahel across the last few years (Institute for Economics & Peace)

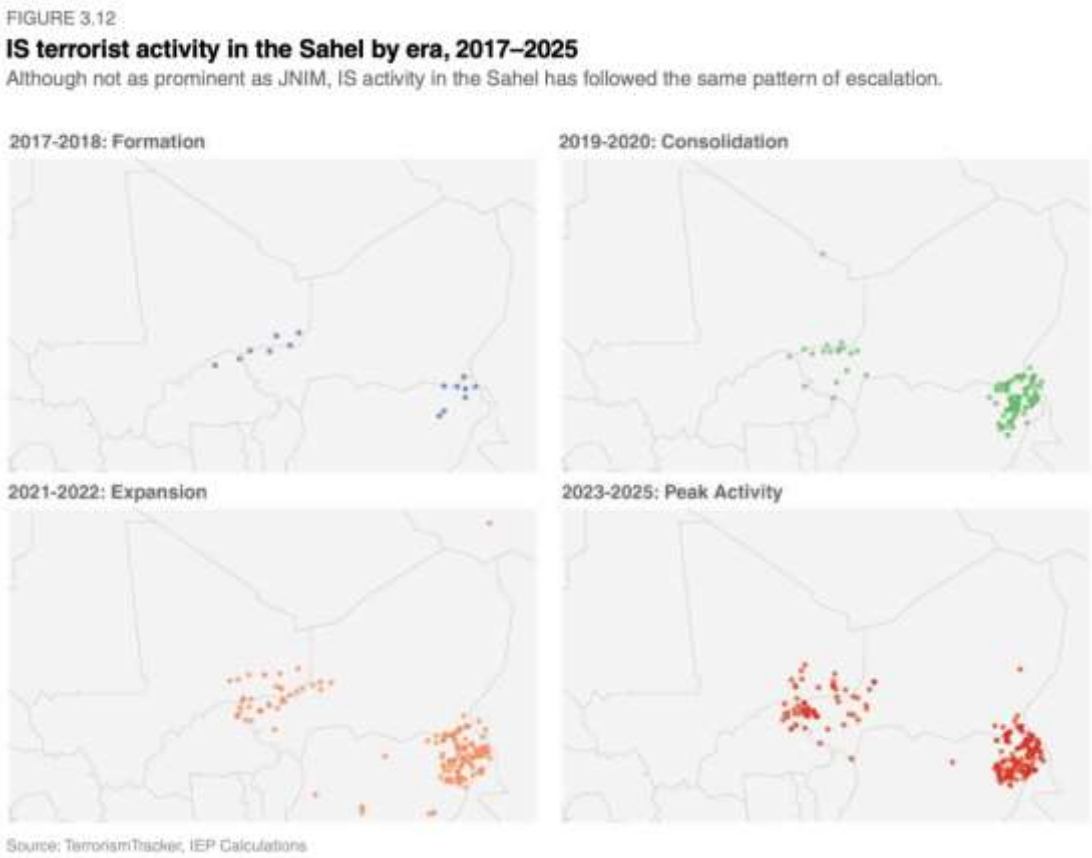

Figure 5: IS-SP activity within the Sahel across the last few years (Institute for Economics & Peace)

Simultaneously, the Lake Chad Basin has also become another major hotspot, due to the insurgency of Boko Haram and other minor groups. These groups have further amplified the regional conflict within the area, showing their full capabilities by continuing to launch attacks on civilian settlements and military bases. The Boko Haram group has been known to extensively exploit the weaknesses in the porous borders of the Sahel regions, with the median distance of their attacks since 2018 having been located within borderland zones.

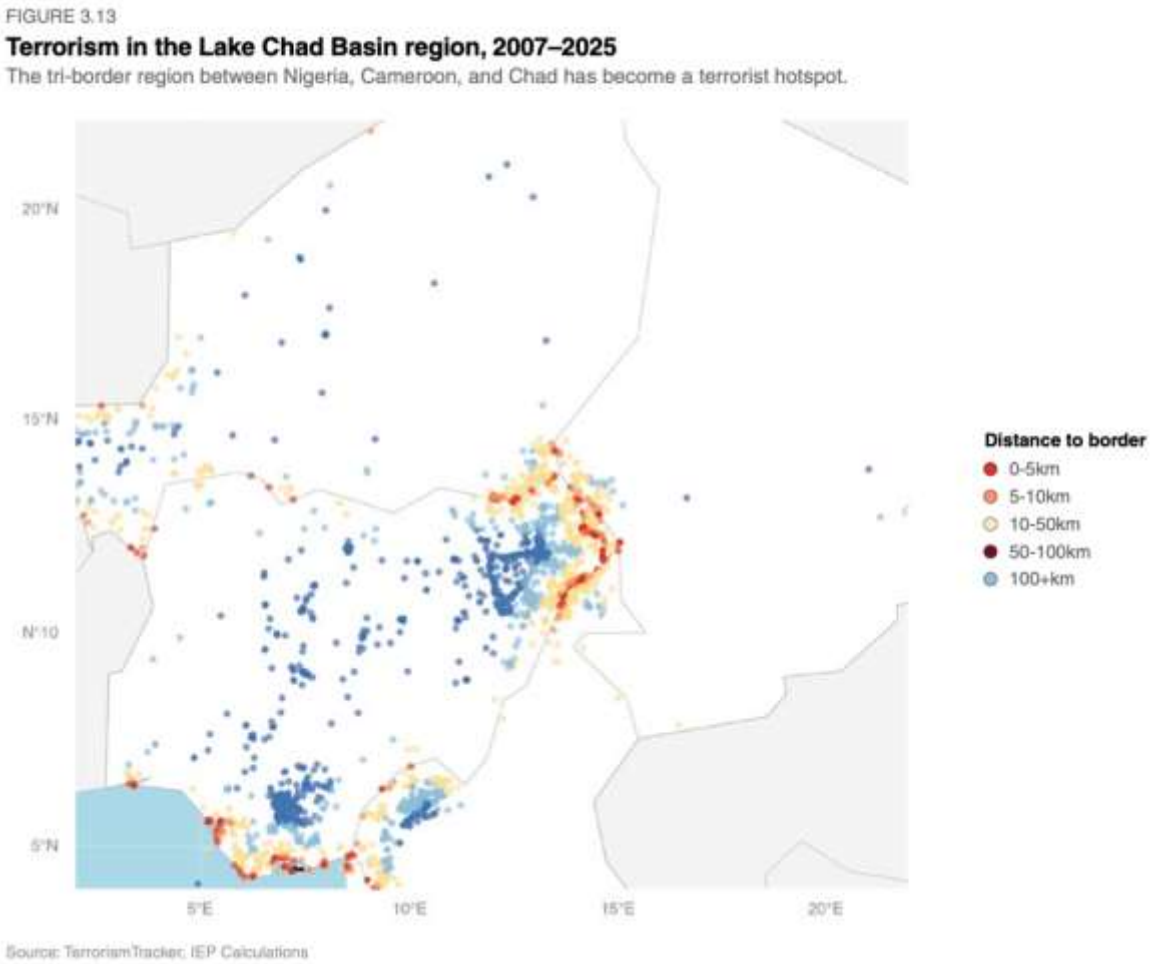

Figure 6: Lake Chad Basin terrorist attacks and proximity to borderlands (Institute for Economics & Peace)

The Sahel region continues to be the epicenter of terrorism, with Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso ranking amongst the top 5 in the Global Terrorism Index. This area has witnessed the most terrorist attacks and faced the most deaths across the world for the past few years, as the volatile governments and the poor living environment make it extremely vulnerable to continued attacks.

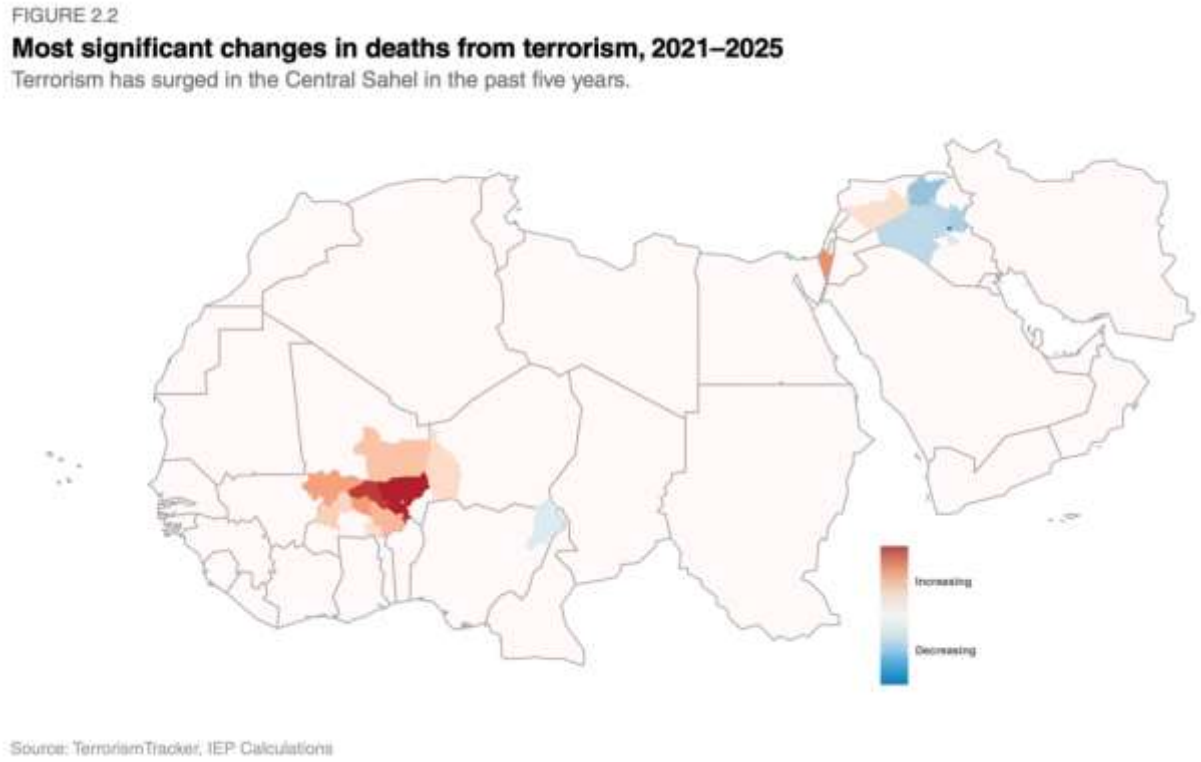

Figure 7: Terrorist activities across Africa and Middle East (Institute for Economics & Peace)

Since 2020, the Sahel has experienced a wave of military coups, with the region heavily overlapping with the Coup Belt, a belt across Africa that has seen a high frequency of coups, which includes many of the Sahelian states. This reflects growing dissatisfaction with the existing government's inability to address insecurity and economic difficulties. These coups have further strained relations within the region with organizations like the Economic Community of West African States and led to shifts in international partnerships, with growing resentment of western states, specifically France, while Russia and Turkey have landed favors with new leaderships.

Major Parties Involved

Republic of Mali

Mali is the epicenter of the Sahel conflict, the nation has faced persistent instability and remains one of the most severely affected states. Its instability dates back to 2012 where the Tuareg rebellion and subsequent jihadist expansion took place. Mali has also experienced repeated military coups in 2020 and 2021, which resulted in a transitional government led by its military forces. To this day,large parts of the country, particularly in the north and center remain outside of effective government control.(International Crisis Group)

In response to the instability, Mali has shifted its foreign partnerships by ending cooperations with France and strengthening connection with Russia's Africa Corps.

Republic of Niger

Niger is a key frontline state in the Sahel conflict, and has also been experiencing escalating instability. It faces significant jihadist activity in its western regions, and is pressured by Boko Haram and IS-SP. In 2023 Niger experienced a military coup that strained its relations with partners. This shift in political power has increased uncertainty over counterterrorism cooperation and regional security coordination. ("The Coup in Niger")

Currently, Niger is deeply affected by cross border insurgency, displacement and unstable state control, especially in rural areas. It has become a critical link in the entire Sahel security crisis.

Burkina Faso

Burkina Faso has a major part of its territory under threat or control by armed groups. The nation has also undergone military coups in 2022, which led to a junta-led government that struggles to contain the escalating conflict.

Jihadist groups such as JNIM and IS-SP have expanded in Burkina Faso and performed frequent attacks on civilians, security forces and infrastructure. Similar to other affected nations, its rural areas are particularly weakened in terms of state control.

Republic of Chad

Chad contributes heavily to the regional security within the Sahel, mainly in the Lake Chad Basin, where it has been one of the more militarily capable states. However, following the death of President Idriss Déby in 2021, the government is now led by a military transitional government, leading to concerns of political stability.

Chad continues to face threats from Boko Haram and Islamic State West Africa Province along its western borders. While the Chadian military has actively participated in regional counterterrorism efforts, their capabilities have been limited by the recent surge in attacks and continued economic challenges.

Islamic State Sahel Province (IS-SP)

IS-SP is an Islamic State-affiliated militant group that operates primarily in the borders of Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger. The group is known for its extreme violence and territorial ambitions, engaging in guerilla warfare, ambushes and attacks on military forces and civilians. It is considered a rival of the JNIM as they compete for influence and control.

IS-SP has continued to exploit the weak governance within the Sahel to recruit members and establish control over rural areas.

Boko Haram

Boko Haram is an Islamic extremist group that originated in northeastern Nigeria. Its activity spans across Niger, Chad, Nigeria and Cameroon. Over time, its influence has weakened due to military pressure, yet it remains a destabilizing force to nearby regions.

Boko Haram is known for widespread attacks, kidnapping and suicide bombing which influences both civilians and security forces. Their activities led to massive displacement and humanitarian crises across the region.

Africa Corps (Previously Wagner Group)

The Africa Corps, formerly known as the Wagner group, is a Russian linked private military organization which operates in parts of the Sahel. They support transitional governments by providing military support, training and other forms of assistance in exchange for political and strategic influence.

The group is involved in combat operations against jihadist insurgents but has faced allegations of human rights abuse and violence against civilians.

Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimin (JNIM)

The transnational conflict in the Sahel isn't simply driven by the governments of nations. There are arrays of armed actors that cooperate, compete and operate independently of one another. The JNIM is one of the most prominent actors. The party was formed in 2017 and has described itself as the official branch of Al-Qaida in Mali and is an alliance of elements of the Organization of Al-Qaida in the Islamic Maghreb in the Sahel, Ansar Eddine, Al-Mourabitoun and others. JNIM is the most active in Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger, and has become one of the most influential independent actors that drives the instability. ("Jama'a Nusrat Ul-Islam Wa Al-Muslimin (JNIM) | Security Council")

The main objective of the JNIM is to establish governance based on the Islamic Law known as Sharia while working towards eliminating foreign military presence and undermining Sahelian governments. Their actions are often framed in religious and anti-imperialist terms, which helps it gain recognition and legitimacy across areas that have strong resentment toward state neglect or foreign influences. Its influence covers large rural areas and undermines governments that are already vulnerable, most importantly, it complicates international efforts in addressing the escalating conflict due to its local integration.

Timeline of Events

Date	Description of event
October 20, 2011	Libya collapsed, leading to spread of weapons and fighters into the Sahel region

January 17, 2012	Tuareg separatists launched an uprising in northern Mali. This was later overtaken by jihadist groups
August 1, 2014	French military operations across the Sahel region are conducted
June 20, 2015	Mali and Tuareg rebel groups signed the Algiers Peace Agreement, aiming to stabilize northern Mali
March 2, 2017	Major jihadist factions merged under al-Qaeda, forming the JNIM
2018-2019	Sharp rise in attacks across regions around Burkina Faso and Niger, indicating escalating tension
August 18, 2020	The president of Mali, Ibrahim Boubacar Keïta was successfully overthrown by the military forces
May 24, 2021	Mali experienced a second coup, where the military force deepened their influence, exacerbating the instability
January 24, 2022	Military forces successfully couped Burkina Faso's government during worsening insecurity
June 30, 2023	The UN Security Council ended the mission in Mali, withdrawing MINUSMA
July 26, 2023	The president of Niger, Mohamed Bazoum was overthrown

Previous Attempts to Resolve the Issue

- On the Launch of Operation Serval, 11 January 2013

Operation Serval was launched by France at the request of the Malian government to drive out Islamist armed groups located in the north of Mali, who have begun launching offensives into central Mali. The operation successfully recaptured major northern cities and repelled insurgents. However, it did not fully eradicate extremist networks, which later adapted through guerrilla tactics, infiltrating rural and cross-border regions.

- On the Establishment of the United Nations Multidimensional Integrated Stabilization Mission in Mali (MINUSMA), 25 April 2013 (**S/RES/2100**)

The United Nations established the United Nations Multidimensional Integrated Stabilization Mission in Mali following the 2012 crisis in Mali to support existing political structures and to stabilize local security. Its mandate included the protection of civilians, helping to reestablish state authority, and delivering humanitarian assistance. Despite becoming one of the UN's largest peacekeeping missions, MINUSMA faced challenges due to the nature of asymmetric warfare, causing limited mobility and frequent casualties caused by armed groups, leading to its withdrawal in 2023 at the request of the Malian government.

- On the Adoption of the United Nations Integrated Strategy for the Sahel (UNISS), 26 June 2013 (**A/RES/67/288**)

The United Nations Integrated Strategy for the Sahel was a framework designed to address the growing tension, with its strategic pillars revolving around governance, resilience, and security within the Sahel region. Its focus was to resolve structural problems in the region including poverty as well as underdevelopment, while bolstering regionwide collaborations. While it allowed for regional coordination, its implementation has been slowed down by funding gaps as well as security risks posed by armed groups.

- On the Establishment of the G5 Sahel Joint Force, 6 February 2014

The G5 Sahel Joint Force, including Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, Chad, and Mauritania was created to coordinate cross-border military operations against terrorist activities within the Sahel region. Supported by many nations abroad and also receiving backing from the United Nations Security Council, the force aimed to improve cooperation in many military aspects to conduct counterterrorism operations against the rise of Jihadist groups. However, the political instability among its member states has reduced its effectiveness. Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger all subsequently withdrew from G5 Sahel due to their coup d'états leading to new military juntas in power, they've since decided to form their own group, the Alliance of Sahel States, which have been staunchly against regional cooperation with other West African nations. With only Chad and Mauritania in the alliance, G5 Sahel was disbanded on 6 December 2023.

- On the Establishment of Operation Barkhane, 1 August 2014

Operation Barkhane succeeded Operation Serval as a broader regional counterterrorism operation across the Sahel. Its goal was to continue combatting the rise in armed Jihadist groups through cooperation with local forces within the region. While it has inflicted heavy casualties on terrorist groups, the operation faced criticism over its effectiveness, and contributed to a rising anti-foreign sentiment within the region due to civilian casualties. Its inability to prevent the spread of insurgency led to its gradual withdrawal and termination in 2022.

- On the Deployment of the Multinational Joint Task Force in the Lake Chad Basin, 29 January 2015

The Multinational Joint Task Force comprised of Nigeria, Chad, Cameroon, and Niger was formed with the goal to combat Boko Haram and other armed groups within the region. The task force improved regional military coordination and was able to reclaim some territory. However, insurgent groups continue to have a foothold in the area, waging asymmetric warfare and exploiting the weak borderlands to continue causing casualties.

- Algiers Peace Agreement, 20 June 2015

The Algiers Accord was a political agreement between Mali and armed groups located in its northern regions, with the goal of ending the Tuareg insurgency. It ensured the decentralization and integration of rebel fighters into

national forces, while granting greater regional autonomy. Though the agreement reduced internal separatist conflict, its implementation is incomplete, and hasn't managed to address the rise of jihadist groups such as JNIM, limiting its effectiveness.

Possible Solutions

Delegates are encouraged to come up with various creative, diplomatic, and procedural measures in the Sahel region. Solutions should aim to balance the viability and respect towards different nations with the urgent need to prevent further progressions of regional instability, protect civilians, and address challenges they face.

1. Strengthening conflict prevention through local communities and mechanisms

Delegates may wish to consider the establishment of local peace committees, early warning systems, and community-based NGO platforms. These systems and organizations should aim for keeping civic, religious, traditional peace, and involve leaders to mediate disputes and local riots, discourage recruitment by armed groups, and actively share information with national authorities. These approaches would maintain respect and peace with the government, while addressing the root issues on a local level.

2. Enhancing Regional Counterterrorism and Security Cooperation

Delegates may explore ways to foster coordination between Sahelian states and organizations, particularly the G5 Sahel, the African Union, and the ECOWAS. Possible measures include communication protocols, creation of legal frameworks, military policies on counterterrorism, and infrastructure support for national armed forces, with the purpose and emphasis on human rights and civilian protection.

3. Addressing the Humanitarian Crisis and displacement

Delegates are encouraged to emphasize the importance of safe humanitarian access to affected populations, such as displaced civilians, and refugees. Solutions may include the establishment of funding for the UN Central Emergency Response Fund (CERF), and support for national disaster management agencies. Delegates may also consider mechanisms to prevent the militarization of humanitarian sites and to offer medicals and aid support.

4. Countering Disinformation and propaganda

Given the role of extremist propaganda and disinformation and their effects in escalating instability, delegates may consider supporting independent media literacy campaigns, community radio, and regional communication strategies and policies that counter extremist narratives. These efforts may involve partnerships with government parties, religious leaders, and educational institutions, while respecting freedom of expression.

5. Promoting Climate Adaptation and Resource governance

highlighting the correlation between climate change, resource scarcity, and the conflict in the Sahel, delegates may encourage investments in sustainable resources and water management, and systems for dealing with and warning about drought and food insecurity. Solutions could include support for water cooperation using geographical features, natural resource governance, and climate adaptation mechanisms.

6. Strengthening Resources for International Missions

Delegates may consider whether existing UN peacekeeping or international political operations in the Sahel require adjusted tasks, enhanced force capabilities, or additional resources to better protect civilians, support stabilization efforts, or eliminate threats. Other measures such as targeted sanctions on armed groups and their supporters, arms embargoes, or monitoring mechanisms could also be explored.

7. Addressing Organized Crime and Illicit Trafficking

Delegates may consider ways to intercept illicit trafficking networks that contribute to instability, including arms, drugs, and human trafficking, as well as other illegal activities. Solutions could include technical assistance for border controls and law enforcement, regional governmental cooperation, and programs to provide humanitarian support for civilians under illicit economies.

8. Long-term Development and Resilience-Building

Delegates are encouraged to prioritize long-term investments in education, public health, economic infrastructure, as essential factors of stability. This may include further investments to existing frameworks such as the UN Integrated Strategy for the Sahel (UNISS) and the Sahel Alliance, and encouraging coordinated engagements with nationally defined priorities.

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